Common Sense by Thomas Paine

Introduction

Common Sense is a 47-page pamphlet written by Thomas Paine in 1775–1776 advocating independence from Great Britain to people in the Thirteen Colonies. Writing in clear and persuasive prose, Paine collected various moral and political arguments to encourage common people in the Colonies to fight for egalitarian government. It was published anonymously on January 10, 1776, at the beginning of the American Revolution and became an immediate sensation.

It was sold and distributed widely and read aloud at taverns and meeting places. In proportion to the population of the colonies at that time (2.5 million), it had the largest sale and circulation of any book published in American history. As of 2006, it remains the all-time best-selling American title and is still in print today. [1]

Key Points Made in Common Sense

***Government's purpose was to serve the people**. Paine described government as a "necessary evil," which existed to give people a structure so they could work together to solve problems and prosper. But to do that, it had to be responsive to people's needs. The British system, Paine argued, failed at that, because it gave the monarchy and nobles in Parliament too much power to thwart the people's elected representatives. "The constitution of England is so exceedingly complex, that the nation may suffer for years together without being able to discover in which part the fault lies, some will say in one and some in another, and every political physician will advise a different medicine," Paine wrote.

***Having a king was a bad idea**. Paine didn't just find fault with British rule of the colonies. He ridiculed the very idea of having a hereditary monarch at all. "In England a king hath little more to do than to make war and give away places, which in plain terms, is to impoverish the nation and set it together by the ears," Paine wrote. "A pretty business indeed for a man to be allowed eight hundred thousand sterling a year for, and worshipped into the bargain! Of more worth is one honest man to society and in the sight of God, than all the crowned ruffians that ever lived."

1. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Common_Sense

***America as the home of the free**. Paine refuted the notion that Americans should be loyal to a mother country that he considered a bad parent. “Even brutes do not devour their young, nor savages make war upon their families,” he wrote. Besides, he argued, America’s real connection was to people everywhere who yearned to escape oppression. "This new world hath been the asylum for the persecuted lovers of civil and religious liberty from every part of Europe," Paine proclaimed. "Hither have they fled, not from the tender embraces of the mother, but from the cruelty of the monster; and it is so far true of England, that the same tyranny which drove the first emigrants from home, pursues their descendants still."

***America had a rare opportunity to create a new nation based on self-rule**. As Paine saw it, both Americans and the British knew it was inevitable that the colonies would break free. "I have never met with a man, either in England or America, who hath not confessed his opinion, that a separation between the countries, would take place one time or other." And that time had come. America had raw materials, from timber and hemp to iron, and the skills that it needed to build and equip an army and navy for its defense. Just as important, the individual colonies had the potential to put aside differences and form a powerful nation. But they needed to do it quickly, before the population grew to a point where new divisions might develop. The moment in history was "that peculiar time, which never happens to a nation but once," he wrote.

***A strong central government was needed**. Paine envisioned that the new nation would have a strong central government, with a constitution that protected individual rights, including freedom of religion. "A firm bargain and a right reckoning make long friends," he argued.[2]

2. https://www.history.com/news/thomas-paine-common-sense-revolution

***Common Sense* Quotes**

"A long habit of not thinking a thing wrong, gives it a superficial appearance of being right and raises at first a formidable outcry in defense of custom. But the tumult soon subsides. Time makes more converts than reason."

Many colonists felt ambivalent about fighting for independence. Everyone had spent their lives under British rule and didn't experience any other form of governance. The tradition was that the King was law. Even though Britain had become a constitutional monarchy, colonists had no representation in the British parliament. Despite the lack of representation and the punitive measures taken by the British crown, colonists were afraid to rebel. Paine argued that independence was inevitable and that colonists should take the initiative first.

"For all men being originally equals, no one by birth could have the right to set up his own family in perpetual preference to all others forever, and tho' himself might deserve some decent degree of honours of his contemporaries, yet his descendants might be far too unworthy to inherit them."

Paine approached governance from the presupposition that all men are created equal and are capable of ruling themselves. Democracy was radical in his time. The idea that people could govern themselves was seen as absurd by those traditionally in power, namely royalty and the aristocracy. He counters with the arbitrary nature of hereditary rule and its inherent weakness of potentially putting unfit rulers in power.

"Small islands, not capable of protecting themselves, are the proper objects for kingdoms to take under their care; but there is something absurd, in supposing a continent to be perpetually governed by an island."

Paine used many arguments for independence in "Common Sense". He used geography as an example. North America and Great Britain were an ocean apart. There is an inherent impracticality in trying to rule something so far away and disconnected. Paine then remarks that an island nation governing a continent many times larger than itself is just ridiculous. The arrangement only makes sense if the situation was reversed.

3. https://www.studysmarter.co.uk/explanations/english-literature/essayists/common-sense/